



Gustave Eiffel University

Internship Report
Master 2 Bézout

Fine-Grained Analysis of the Hyperscan Engine

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1

Introduction

Since Knuth’s announcement of the term *analysis of algorithms* [4, Preface], the field has grown to include highly specialized subfields. A basic classification is based on two aspects. The first aspect is the scenario under which the performance of an algorithm is analyzed, which concludes worst-case and average-case analysis. In general, average-case analysis is more informative than worst-case analysis, and is often more challenging to perform, since it requires a probabilistic model of the input that is tractable, yet expressive enough. For example, in the case of regular languages, it may not be a good idea to generate their syntax trees uniformly at random [5]. Interestingly, average-case analysis opens up the door to apply techniques from other fields, such as probability theory and analytic combinatorics, and raises new question, such as those about the limiting objects when the input size tends to infinity. The second aspect is the underlying underlying cost model, which can be the uniform or word-RAM model. The main purpose is to align quantitative analysis with practical performance, demonstrated by execution time. Analysis of modern algorithms requires new cost models to natively capture hardware features, such as caching, branch prediction and parallelism.

In this internship, we study Hyperscan a regular expression matching engine that leverages SIMD parallelism to achieve high performance. Acknowledging the sophisticated design of Hyperscan, we proposed related questions and attempted to answer them. Hyperscan works by extracting possible strings from a regular expression, and then matching them once in parallel by its SIMD string matchers. Hence it is natural to analyze statistics related to those strings under a distribution. In particular, our question is to understand the asymptotic of the length of the longest strings extracted from a regular expression. Other questions are also posed clearly although not studied to a considerable extend. Details are given in the next chapter.

The rest of the report is organized as follows. In **Chapter 2**, we present Hyperscan and problems arose in the analysis. **Chapter 3** contains our results on the question of the length of the longest strings. Before each proof, we present the motivation and reasoning behind our approaches, which the reader can optionally skip and then go back after reading the proof. We place details of popular theoretical and experimental techniques in **Chapter 4**, where the reader can refer to for background knowledge. Finally, we conclude in **Chapter 5** with a summary of our work and future directions.

2

An Overview of the Hyperscan Engine

The regular expression matching engine Hyperscan [9] was primarily developed by the startup company Sensory Networks in 2008, and was later acquired and open-sourced by Intel in 2013. Closed source in 2023 at version 5.4, it is forked into Vectorscan [8] by VectorCamp to support more architectures like ARM. Since Vectorscan is still being actively maintained publicly, analyzing its core Hyperscan functionality still provides valuable insights into the design and optimization of high-performance regular expression matching engines, interesting to both academia and industry.

Hyperscan is designed to match a set of regular expressions against a stream of data, with its primary use case being deep packet inspection. The engine leverages SIMD (Single Instruction, Multiple Data) features supported by modern CPUs, which uses longer registers to process multiple similar operations in one instruction. Architecturally, it operates in two distinct phases: the compilation phase and the execution phase. It supports two modes of operation: block mode and stream mode. In block mode, the engine processes a single block of data at a time, while in stream mode, it maintains state across multiple blocks, allowing for continuous matching over a data stream. We focus on the block mode.

2.1 Compilation

An overview of the compilation process is illustrated in Figure 2.1. The compilation phase provides central APIs, such as the `hs_compile` function. The function accepts a set of regular expressions. A facade object of class `NG` is initialized, which consumes a compile context of type `CompileContext`. Through the function `addExpression`, each expression is converted into a Glushkov NFA [2] (through `buildGraph`) and added to the facade (through `NG.addGraph`).

In `NG.addGraph`, the NFA is firstly decomposed base on its language through `calcComponents`. If its language is L , it may be split into NFAs whose languages are $L_1, L_2, \dots, L_n$ such that

$$L = L_1 \cup L_2 \cup \dots \cup L_n.$$

The components are added one by one through `addComponent`, which then passed to the Violet subengine through the `doViolet` function, which in turn calls `doInitialVioletTransform` and `RoseBuild.addRose`.

In `doInitialVioletTransform`, the graph analyses described in the Hyperscan paper—namely dominant path, dominant region, and network flow analysis—are performed. These analyses decompose

2.1 Compilation

the NFA into literals and sub-FAs, yielding a dependency graph that dictates the matching order. At this phase (**RoseInGraph**), each literal is a vertex and each sub-FA acts as an edge. This graph is then passed to the Rose subengine for deduplication of FAs, compilation into bytecode, and execution orchestration. Notably, in the subsequent (**RoseGraph**) representation, the sub-FAs are instead attached directly to their associated literal vertices via **left** or **suffix** properties. Multiple FAs may be merged into an FA with multiple initial states. Therefore, the **suffix** property also contains a sub-property **top** indicating which initial state should be chosen.

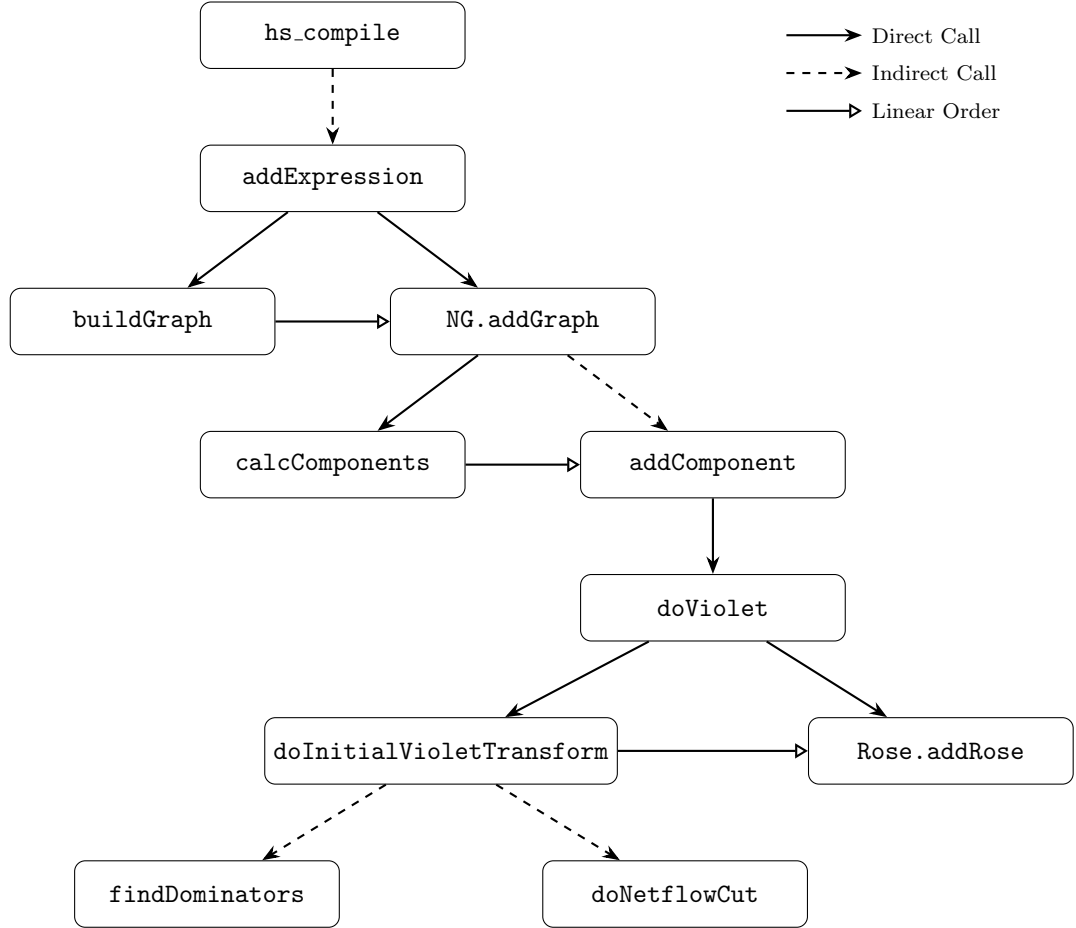


Figure 2.1: Dependency graph of main functions in the compilation phase.

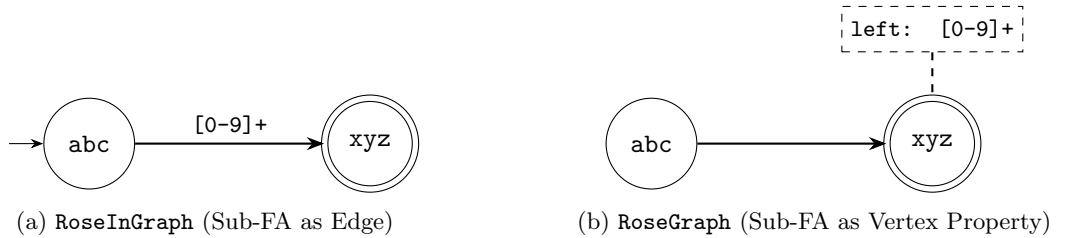


Figure 2.2: The dependency graphs by Violet and Rose.

Consider an example of a regular expression **abc[0-9]+xyz**. If we discard heuristics for short literals, then the graphs returned by Violet and Rose are as in Figures 2.2a and 2.2b, respectively. They both mean that if there is a match of **abc** that *ends* at position i (excluded) and a match of **xyz** that *starts* at position j (included), such that $j - i > 0$, then the subtext at $[i, j)$ must match the sub-FA **[0-9]+**. Further optimization imposes that

$$m \leq j - i \leq M,$$

where m and M are the minimum and maximum *widths* of the sub-FA, i.e., the minimum and maximum lengths of possible strings that match the sub-FA.

2.2 Execution

An overview of the execution phase is illustrated in Figure 2.3. The process begins at `hs_scan`. There are three execution scenarios already determined by Rose: (1) the set of patterns are all literals (2) there are no literals that wake up FAs, and (3) literals wake up FAs. The last scenario is the most common. Its flow reaches `roseBlockExec`, where now one of its string matchers is called through `hwlmExec` together with a `roseCallback` function. The `roseCallback` function eventually calls `roseRunProgram`. Here is where the `left` or `suffix` FAs are checked, waken up and executed.

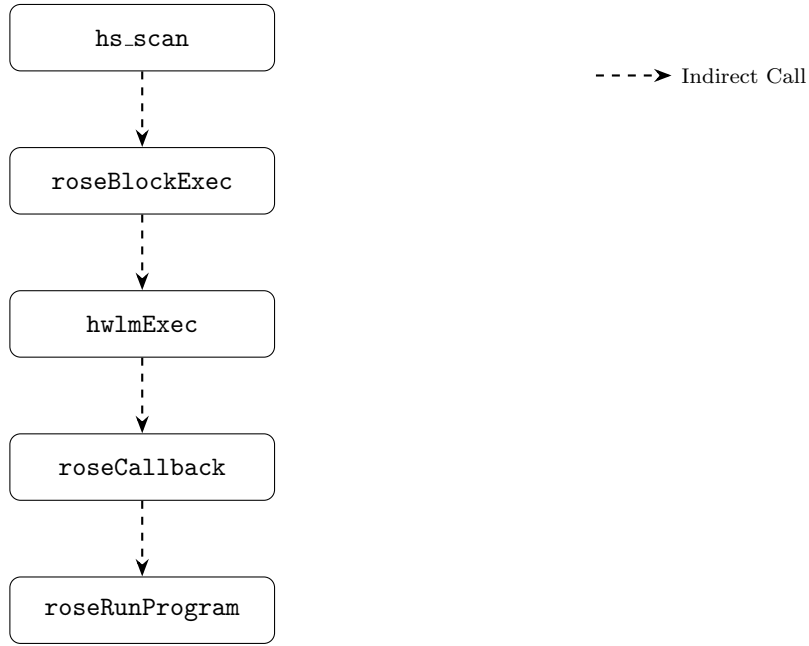


Figure 2.3: Dependency graph of main functions in the execution phase.

2.3 The FDR Matcher

There are at least four SIMD-based string matchers in Hyperscan: Noodle is used when there is a single literal, Teddy [7] or Harry [10] when there are 2 to 300, and FDR when there are more than 300. The last three matchers are all prefilter-based. Firstly, they group the literals into a set of *buckets*. Each bucket can be regarded as an indeterminate string (see e.g., [3])

Definition 2.1. Let Σ be an alphabet. An indeterminate string P of length n over Σ is a sequence of n non-empty sets of characters from Σ , i.e.,

$$P = p_1 p_2 \dots p_n,$$

where $\emptyset \neq p_i \subseteq \Sigma$ for all $i \in [1, n]$. The subset Σ is usually referred to as the *don't care* character. A string T over Σ matches the indeterminate string P if and only if $|T| = n$ and $T[i] \in p_i$ for all $i \in [1, n]$. ■

Let us remark that the set of indeterminate strings over Σ is a strict subset of the set of star-free

regular expressions over Σ . For example, the regular expression $\mathbf{ab|cd}$ is not an indeterminate string. Let $\{P_1, P_2, \dots, P_k\}$ be the set of literals in a bucket. Let p_{ij} be the j -th character of literal P_i . The literals are right-aligned and padded with the don't care character $*$ to form an indeterminate string $\mathbf{P}$ of length $n = \max\{|P_1|, |P_2|, \dots, |P_k|\}$, i.e., $\mathbf{P} = \mathbf{p_1p_2 \dots p_n}$, where

$$\mathbf{p_{n-j}} = \begin{cases} \{p_{i,|P_i|-j} \mid 1 \leq i \leq k, j \leq |P_i|\}, & \text{if } p_{i,|P_i|-j} \text{ is defined for every } i, \\ \Sigma, & \text{otherwise.} \end{cases}$$

Let T be a text. The string matchers attempt to check if T matches $\mathbf{P}$, and if so, which literal P_i is matched. The FDR matcher is an SIMD extension of the Shift-Or algorithm (Appendix A.1).

2.4 Related Problems

2.4.1 Optimizing regular expression decomposition

Both representations in Figure 2.2 are likely suboptimal for theoretical analysis. Firstly, the sub-FA may appear several times, even though it only appear once in the regular expression, for example in the case of $\mathbf{(abc|def)[0-9]^+xyz}$. Secondly, although we had to mark $\mathbf{xyz}$ as a terminal vertex in Figure 2.2, this is not strictly accurate: the matching process terminates at the end of the sub-FA, not at the end of $\mathbf{xyz}$. If there are remaining FAs or literals to the right, it is the sub-FA for $\mathbf{[0-9]^+}$ that will determine the next matching position. Therefore, we propose a more convenient representation as follows. Each vertex is either a literal or a sub-FA. There are three types of directed edges.

- Edges that uses the *end* positions of the matches of the source vertex to determine the *start* positions of the matches of the target vertex. They connect two literals or a literal and a sub-FA. We call this type of edge **setStart**.
- Edges that uses the *start* positions of the matches of the source vertex to determine the *end* positions of the matches of the target vertex. They connect a literal and a sub-FA. We call this type of edge **setEnd**.
- Edges that acts as a pure trigger, without any position information. They connect two sub-FAs. We call this type of edge **trigger**.

Consider another example of $\mathbf{abc[0-9]^+xyz(de)^*}$. In its dependency graph in the new representation is as in Figure 2.4.

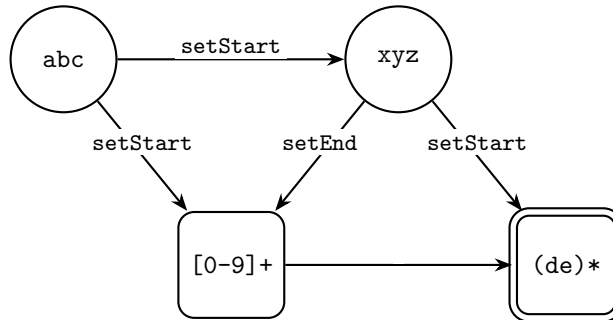


Figure 2.4: Proposed sequential dependency graph representation for $\mathbf{abc[0-9]^+xyz}$.

2.4.2 Analysis of the FDR string matcher

2.4.3 Statistics of regular expressions

Suppose that the regex trees are generated according to a BST-like distribution. The average length of the longest literals of an n -node tree satisfies the recurrence

$$Y_{n+2} \stackrel{d}{=} I \left(Y_{U_n}^{(1)} + Y_{n+1-U_n}^{(2)} \right) + J \max \left(Y_{U_n}^{(1)}, Y_{n+1-U_n}^{(2)} \right), n \geq 1, \quad Y_1 = 1, Y_2 = 0. \quad (2.1)$$

Superscripts denote mutually independent copies. The variable U_n is uniformly distributed on $\{1, \dots, n\}$. The variables I and J are Bernoulli distributed with expectations u and v respectively, such that $I + J \leq 1$. We reuse the same variables $Y_{U_n}^{(1)}, Y_{n+1-U_n}^{(2)}$ and U_n across both terms, since the branches are not taken at the same time. The variables I and J are also reused, since at every new iteration, we sample a new subtree independently.

Details analysis for the asymptotic behavior of $\mathbb{E}[Y_n]$ is given in the next chapter.

3

The Length of Longest Literals

3.1 Lower and upper bounds

Denote $y_n := \mathbb{E}[Y_n]$ for $n \geq 1$. Taking the expectation of both sides in the recurrence (2.1), we have for $n \geq 1$,

$$\begin{aligned} y_{n+2} &= \frac{u}{n} \sum_{i=1}^n (y_i + y_{n+1-i}) + \frac{v}{n} \mathbb{E} \left[\max \left(Y_i^{(1)}, Y_{n+1-i}^{(2)} \right) \right] \\ &= \frac{2u}{n} \sum_{i=1}^n y_i + \frac{v}{n} \mathbb{E} \left[\max \left(Y_i^{(1)}, Y_{n+1-i}^{(2)} \right) \right]. \end{aligned}$$

Using the inequality $\max(a, b) \leq a + b$ for $a, b \geq 0$, we have

$$y_{n+2} \leq \frac{2(u+v)}{n} \sum_{i=1}^n y_i.$$

Since the right-hand side of the inequality is an increasing function of $(y_1, \dots, y_n)$, the sequence (y_n) is bounded above by the solution to the recurrence

$$z_{n+2} = \frac{2(u+v)}{n} \sum_{i=1}^n z_i, \quad n \geq 1, \quad z_1 = 1, z_2 = 0. \quad (3.1)$$

Similarly, the inequality $\max(a, b) \geq \frac{1}{2}(a+b)$ gives a lower bound sequence

$$z_{n+2} = \frac{2u+v}{n} \sum_{i=1}^n z_i, \quad n \geq 1, \quad z_1 = 1, z_2 = 0. \quad (3.2)$$

It is possible to employ a transfer theorem in analytic combinatorics to analyze the asymptotic behavior of these recurrences (Lemma A.1). The lower bound can be improved by tightening the lower bound of the expectation of the maximum

$$\mathbb{E} \left[\max \left(Y_i^{(1)}, Y_{n+1-i}^{(2)} \right) \right] \geq \max \left(\mathbb{E} \left[Y_i^{(1)} \right], \mathbb{E} \left[Y_{n+1-i}^{(2)} \right] \right) = \max(y_i, y_{n+1-i}).$$

Note that this bound is not sharp, the equality holds only when $Y_i^{(1)} = Y_{n+1-i}^{(2)}$ a.s. The lower bound recurrence is then given by

$$z_{n+2} = \frac{2u}{n} \sum_{i=1}^n z_i + \frac{v}{n} \sum_{i=1}^n \max(z_i, z_{n+1-i}), \quad n \geq 1, \quad z_1 = 1, z_2 = 0. \quad (3.3)$$

Detailed analysis of (3.3) is given in the next section.

3.2 Asymptotics of the lower bound recurrence

The sequence defined by (3.3) is bounded between those defined by (3.1) and (3.2). If $2u + v > 1$, then both (3.1) and (3.2) grow as a pure power of n , without any lower-order factor like the logarithm. We conjecture that in this case (3.3) also grows as a pure power of n . In this section, we always refer to (z_n) as the sequence defined by (3.3), unless otherwise stated. The set of conditions on the parameters u and v is thus given by

$$u, v \geq 0, \quad u < 1, \quad u + v \leq 1, \quad 2u + v > 1. \quad (3.4)$$

In Theorem 3.10, we will we to strengthen the conditions to

$$u, v \geq 0, \quad \frac{1}{2} < u < 1, \quad u + v \leq 1. \quad (3.5)$$

Let us carry out a heuristic to find out the power. Assume that $z_n \sim Cn^\alpha$ for some constants $c > 0$ and $\alpha > 0$. Then, substituting into (3.3), we get

$$\begin{aligned} Cn^\alpha &\sim \frac{2u}{n} \sum_{i=1}^n Ci^\alpha + \frac{v}{n} \sum_{i=1}^n C \max(i^\alpha, (n+1-i)^\alpha) \\ &\sim C \left(\frac{2u}{n} \int_0^n Cx^\alpha dx + \frac{v}{n} \int_0^n C \max(x^\alpha, (n-x)^\alpha) dx \right) \\ &= C \left(\frac{2u}{n} \int_0^n x^\alpha dx + \frac{2v}{n} \cdot \int_{n/2}^n x^\alpha dx \right) \\ &= C \left(\frac{2u}{n} \cdot \frac{n^{\alpha+1}}{\alpha+1} + \frac{2v}{n} \cdot \frac{n^{\alpha+1} - (n/2)^{\alpha+1}}{\alpha+1} \right) \\ &= \frac{C}{\alpha+1} (2(u+v) - v2^{-\alpha}) n^\alpha. \end{aligned}$$

Thus, we must have

$$\alpha + v2^{-\alpha} = 2(u+v) - 1. \quad (3.6)$$

Note that $\alpha > 0$, since otherwise $2u + v = 1$. A natural goal is to try to escape from the maximum operator. However, (z_n) fluctuates in the first iterations, and the time where it begins to increase depends on the parameters u and v . An extreme case is that when

$$u \rightarrow 1/2 + \text{ and } v \rightarrow 0+,$$

the sequence (z_n) fluctuates for a long time before increasing consistently.

add figure and discuss the case when $z_2 = 1$.

It turns out that this property of *eventual monotonicity* is sufficient to escape from the maximum operator. Indeed, assume that there exists N_1 such that $z_{n+1} \geq z_n$ for all $n \geq N_1$. Since (z_n) is unbounded, there exists $N_2 \geq N_1$ such that for all $n \geq N_2$, we have both $z_{n+1} \geq \max_{1 \leq i \leq N_1} z_i$ and $z_{n+1} \geq z_n$. That is

$$\forall n \geq N_2, \quad z_{n+1} \geq \max_{1 \leq i \leq n} z_i.$$

Taking $N_3 = 2N_2 - 1$, we have

$$\forall n \geq N_3, \forall \frac{N_3+1}{2} \leq i \leq N_3, \quad z_i \geq z_{n+1-i}.$$

3.2 Asymptotics of the lower bound recurrence

The question about when it stops fluctuating is itself interesting, which we leave open.

Open question 1 *In terms of u and v , what is the first index N such that $(z_n)_{n \geq N}$ is increasing?*

We start with weaker results that do not require escaping from the maximum operator. Define

$$F(x, y) = u(x + y) + v \max(x, y), x, y \in [0, 1]. \quad (3.7)$$

We rewrite our recurrence as

$$z_{n+2} = \frac{1}{n} \sum_{i=1}^n F(z_i, z_{n+1-i}), \quad n \geq 1, \quad z_1 = 1, z_2 = 0. \quad (3.8)$$

If $z_n \sim Cn^\alpha$, we can try to approximate F as follows.

Lemma 3.1 *For every $\alpha \in (0, 1]$, we have*

$$\frac{1}{n} \sum_{i=1}^n F(i^\alpha, (n+1-i)^\alpha) \sim n^\alpha \int_0^1 F(x^\alpha, (1-x)^\alpha).$$

Proof. Rewrite the asymptotics as a limit

$$\frac{1}{n} \sum_{i=1}^n F\left(\left(\frac{i}{n}\right)^\alpha, \left(1 - \frac{i}{n} + \frac{1}{n}\right)^\alpha\right) \rightarrow \int_0^1 F(x^\alpha, (1-x)^\alpha).$$

The function on the right-hand side is continuous on $[0, 1]$, and the left-hand side is different from its Riemann sum only by a perturbation $1/n$ in the second argument. We show that the perturbation is negligible. Define for $x \in [0, 1]$ the functions

$$f_n(x) = F\left(x^\alpha, \left(1 - x + \frac{1}{n}\right)^\alpha\right) \text{ and } f(x) = F(x^\alpha, (1-x)^\alpha),$$

For $a, b, c \geq 0$ and $\alpha \in (0, 1]$, we have

$$|\max(a, b) - \max(a, c)| \leq |b - c| \text{ and } (a + b)^\alpha \leq a^\alpha + b^\alpha.$$

Hence,

$$\|f_n - f\|_\infty \leq \sup_{x \in [0, 1]} (u + v) \left(\left(1 - x + \frac{1}{n}\right)^\alpha - (1 - x)^\alpha \right) \leq (u + v) \frac{1}{n^\alpha} \rightarrow 0.$$

Therefore,

$$\left| \frac{1}{n} \sum_{i=1}^n f_n\left(\frac{i}{n}\right) - \frac{1}{n} \sum_{i=1}^n f\left(\frac{i}{n}\right) \right| \leq \|f_n - f\|_\infty \rightarrow 0.$$

□

Let

$$\Lambda(\alpha) = \int_0^1 F(x^\alpha, (1-x)^\alpha) dx = \frac{2(u+v) - v2^{-\alpha}}{\alpha + 1}.$$

Then Λ is strictly decreasing. Indeed,

$$\begin{aligned} \Lambda'(\alpha) &= \frac{v2^{-\alpha} \ln 2}{\alpha + 1} - \frac{2(u+v) - v2^{-\alpha}}{(\alpha + 1)^2} = \frac{v2^{-\alpha}((\alpha + 1) \ln 2 + 1) - 2(u+v)}{(\alpha + 1)^2}, \\ (2^{-\alpha}((\alpha + 1) \ln 2 + 1))' &= -2^{-\alpha}(\alpha + 1) \ln^2(2) < 0. \end{aligned}$$

3.2 Asymptotics of the lower bound recurrence

Hence,

$$(\alpha + 1)^2 \Lambda'(\alpha) < (\alpha + 1)^2 \Lambda'(0) = -(2u + (1 - \ln 2)v) < 0.$$

Therefore, there exists a unique α such that $\Lambda(\alpha) = 1$, which is the solution to (3.6). Furthermore, $\Lambda(\beta) < 1$ for all $\beta > \alpha$ and $\Lambda(\beta) > 1$ for all $\beta < \alpha$. That helps us prove a weaker asymptotic theorem.

Theorem 3.2 *Let α be the solution to (3.6). Then, $z_n = n^{\alpha+o(1)}$.*

Proof. Let $A_n(\beta) = \frac{1}{n} \sum_{i=1}^n F(i^\beta, (n+1-i)^\beta)$. Firstly, we prove the upper bound. Assume that $\beta > \alpha$. Then, $\Lambda(\beta) < 1$. Hence there exists N such that for all $n \geq N$,

$$A_n(\beta) < n^\beta < (n+2)^\beta.$$

Let $M_n = \max_{1 \leq k \leq n} \frac{z_i}{k^\beta}$. For $n \geq N$, we have

$$z_{n+2} = \frac{1}{n} \sum_{i=1}^n F(z_i, z_{n+1-i}) \leq M_n A_n(\beta) < M_n (n+2)^\beta.$$

Hence, $\frac{z_{n+2}}{(n+2)^\beta} < M_n$. Or (M_n) is eventually non-increasing. Therefore, $z_n = O(n^\beta)$.

We argue similarly for the lower bound, with an adjustment for z_2 . We have

$$A_n(\beta) \sim n^\beta \sim (n+2)^\beta \text{ and } A_n(\beta) \sim \frac{1}{n} \sum_{i=3}^{n-2} F(i^\beta, (n+1-i)^\beta).$$

Assume that $\beta < \alpha$. Then, $\Lambda(\beta) > 1$. Hence there exists $N \geq 3$ such that for all $n \geq N$,

$$\frac{1}{n} \sum_{i=3}^{n-2} F(i^\beta, (n+1-i)^\beta) > (n+2)^\beta.$$

Let $m_n = \min_{3 \leq i \leq n-2} \frac{z_i}{i^\beta}$. For $n \geq N$, we have

$$z_{n+2} \geq \frac{1}{n} \sum_{i=3}^{n-2} F(z_i, z_{n+1-i}) \geq m_n \frac{1}{n} \sum_{i=3}^{n-2} F(i^\beta, (n+1-i)^\beta) > m_n (n+2)^\beta.$$

Hence, $\frac{z_{n+2}}{(n+2)^\beta} > m_n$. Or (m_n) is eventually increasing. Therefore, $z_n = \Omega(n^\beta)$. $\square$

Next, we present the stronger big- Θ result. The proof is done by fine-grained induction. We provide integral bounds for the sum of the maximums to be used in the induction step.

Lemma 3.3 *Let $f : [0, \infty) \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$ be a increasing function. For every integer $n \geq 1$, we have*

$$S_1 := \sum_{i=0}^{n-1} \max(f(i), f(n-1-i)) \leq 2 \int_{n/2}^n f(x) dx \leq S_2 := \sum_{i=1}^n \max(f(i), f(n+1-i)).$$

Proof. We first prove the upper bound on the first sum. We will use the following bounds for $t \geq 0$

$$f(t) \leq \int_t^{t+1} f(x) dx \leq 2 \int_{t+1/2}^{t+1} f(x) dx.$$

If $n = 2k$, we have

$$S_1 = 2 \sum_{i=k}^{2k-1} f(i) \leq 2 \sum_{i=k}^{2k-1} \int_i^{i+1} f(x) dx.$$

3.2 Asymptotics of the lower bound recurrence

If $n = 2k + 1$, we have

$$S_1 = 2 \sum_{i=k+1}^{2k} f(i) + f(k) \leq 2 \sum_{i=k+1}^{2k} \int_i^{i+1} f(x) dx + 2 \int_{k+1/2}^{k+1} f(x) dx.$$

The omit the proof for the lower bound on the second sum, while pointing out the bounds that would be used. For $t \geq 1$, we have

$$f(t) \geq \int_{t-1}^t f(x) dx \geq 2 \int_{t-1}^{t-1/2} f(x) dx.$$

□

Theorem 3.4 *Let α be the solution to (3.6). Then, $z_n = \Theta(n^\alpha)$.*

Proof. We prove the lower bound. It is clear that $z_n > 0$ for all $n \neq 2$. The main idea is to isolate z_2 . The induction hypothesis is $z_n \geq K(n + L)^\alpha$ for $n \neq 2$. The base cases and the exact constants are determined later. We need

$$\max(z_2, z_{n-1}) = z_{n-1} \geq \max((2 + L)^\alpha, (n - 1 + L)^\alpha).$$

Hence consider $n \geq 3$ and then

$$\begin{aligned} nz_{n+2} &= 2u \sum_{i=1}^n z_i + v \sum_{i=1}^n \max(z_i, z_{n+1-i}) \\ &\geq K \left(2u \sum_{i=1}^n (i + L)^\alpha + v \sum_{i=1}^n \max((i + L)^\alpha, (n + 1 - i + L)^\alpha) \right) - K2u(2 + L)^\alpha \\ &\geq K \left(2u \int_0^n (x + L)^\alpha dx + 2v \int_{n/2}^n (x + L)^\alpha dx \right) - K2u(2 + L)^\alpha. \end{aligned}$$

Let

$$\begin{aligned} A_n &= 2u \int_0^n (x + L)^\alpha dx + 2v \int_{n/2}^n (x + L)^\alpha dx \\ &= \frac{1}{\alpha + 1} \left((2u + 2v)(n + L)^{\alpha+1} - 2v \left(\frac{n}{2} + L \right)^{\alpha+1} \right). \end{aligned}$$

Using the expansions

$$\begin{aligned} (n + L)^{\alpha+1} &= n^{\alpha+1} + (\alpha + 1)Ln^\alpha + O(n^{\alpha-1}), \\ \left(\frac{n}{2} + L \right)^{\alpha+1} &= 2^{-\alpha+1}n^{\alpha+1} + (\alpha + 1)L2^{-\alpha}n^\alpha + O(n^{\alpha-1}), \end{aligned}$$

we get

$$\begin{aligned} A_n &= n^{\alpha+1} + L(2u + 2v - 2v2^{-\alpha})n^\alpha + O(n^{\alpha-1}) \\ &= n^{\alpha+1} + L(\alpha + 1 - v2^{-\alpha})n^\alpha + O(n^{\alpha-1}). \end{aligned}$$

On the other hand,

$$n(n + L + 2)^\alpha = n^{\alpha+1} + \alpha(L + 2)n^\alpha + O(n^{\alpha-1}).$$

Hence,

$$A_n - 2u(2 + L)^\alpha - n(n + L + 2)^\alpha = (L(1 - v2^{-\alpha}) - 2\alpha)n^\alpha + O(n^{\alpha-1}).$$

Since $1 - v2^{-\alpha} > 0$, choose $L > \frac{2\alpha}{1 - v2^{-\alpha}}$, then there exists N such that for all $n \geq N$,

$$A_n - 2u(2 + L)^\alpha - n(n + L + 2)^\alpha \geq 0,$$

3.2 Asymptotics of the lower bound recurrence

implying that $z_{n+2} \geq K(n+L+2)^\alpha$. Finally, we choose $K = \min_{i \in \{1,3,\dots,N+1\}} \frac{z_i}{(i+L)^\alpha} > 0$ to satisfy the base cases.

Now we prove the upper bound. Our induction hypothesis is $z_n \leq K(n-1)^\alpha$ for $n \geq 2$, for some constant $K > 1$. The base case $z_2 = 0$ is trivially satisfied. For $n \geq 2$, we have

$$\begin{aligned}
nz_{n+2} &= 2u + 2u \sum_{i=2}^n z_i + v \sum_{i=1}^n \max(z_i, z_{n+1-i}) \\
&\leq K \left(2u \sum_{i=1}^{n-1} i^\alpha + v \sum_{i=0}^{n-1} \max(i^\alpha, (n-1-i)^\alpha) \right) + 2u \\
&\leq K \left(2u \int_1^n x^\alpha dx + 2v \int_{n/2}^n x^\alpha dx \right) + 2u \\
&= K \left(2u \frac{n^{\alpha+1} - 1}{\alpha + 1} + 2v \frac{n^{\alpha+1} - (n/2)^{\alpha+1}}{\alpha + 1} \right) + 2u \\
&= Kn^{\alpha+1} \frac{2u + 2v - v2^{-\alpha}}{\alpha + 1} - \frac{2Ku}{\alpha + 1} + 2u \\
&= Kn^{\alpha+1} - \frac{2Ku}{\alpha + 1} + 2u.
\end{aligned}$$

The first inequality is valid by noticing that

$$\max(z_1, z_n) = \max(1, z_n) \leq \max(1, K(n-1)^\alpha) = \max(0, K(n-1)^\alpha).$$

The second inequality uses Lemma 3.3. Choose $K = \alpha + 1 > 1$, then $z_{n+2} \leq Kn^\alpha \leq K(n+2)^\alpha$. $\square$

Remark 3.1. In the proof of the lower bound we exploit the fact that $(n+L)^{\alpha+1}$ dominates $n(n+L+2)^{\alpha+1}$ when L is large enough. Actually, we also have $(n-L)^{\alpha+1} \ll n(n-L+2)^{\alpha+1}$ when L is large enough. However, if we apply the same idea to the upper bound, we cannot start the hypothesis from the beginning, but only after some $n > L$. We can overcome that by choosing $L = 1$ and saving a fixed budget $2u$ in the first term. Nicely, that also leads to an algebraic convenience.

We proceed to the exact asymptotics $z_n \sim Cn^\alpha$. The idea is to use loose inequalities to bootstrap more basic properties, then upgrade step by step with tighter inequalities. The next lemma is our first step, where we use a loose inequality $\max(a, b) \leq a + b$ to show that the difference between consecutive terms vanishes. To begin with, let us define for $n \geq 1$ the difference

$$\Delta z_n = z_n - z_{n-1}.$$

Lemma 3.5 (Vanishing difference) *We have $|\Delta z_n| \rightarrow 0$.*

Proof. For $n \geq 2$, we have

$$\begin{aligned}
nz_{n+2} &= 2u \sum_{i=1}^n z_i + v \sum_{i=1}^n \max(z_i, z_{n+1-i}), \\
(n-1)z_{n+1} &= 2u \sum_{i=1}^{n-1} z_i + v \sum_{i=1}^{n-1} \max(z_i, z_{n-i}).
\end{aligned}$$

Hence,

$$\begin{aligned}
n\Delta z_{n+1} &= 2uz_n + v \max(z_n, z_1) - z_{n+1} + v \sum_{i=1}^{n-1} (\max(z_i, z_{n+1-i}) - \max(z_i, z_{n-i})) \\
&= 2uz_n + v \max(z_n, z_1) - z_{n+1} + v \sum_{i=1}^{n-1} (\max(z_{n-i}, z_{i+1}) - \max(z_{n-i}, z_i)).
\end{aligned} \tag{3.9}$$

3.2 Asymptotics of the lower bound recurrence

Using $\max(z_n, z_1) \leq z_n + z_1$, we have

$$\begin{aligned} n\Delta z_{n+1} &\leq 2uz_n + v(z_n + z_1) - vz_{n+1} + v \sum_{i=1}^{n-1} (\max(z_{n-i}, z_{i+1}) - \max(z_{n-i}, z_i)) \\ &\leq 2uz_n + vz_1 + v(z_n - z_{n+1}) + v \sum_{i=1}^{n-1} (\max(z_{n-i}, z_{i+1}) - \max(z_{n-i}, z_i)) \end{aligned}$$

Using $|\max(a, b) - \max(a, c)| \leq |b - c|$, we have

$$\begin{aligned} n|\Delta z_{n+1}| &\leq 2uz_n + vz_1 + v|\Delta z_n| + v \sum_{i=1}^{n-1} |\Delta z_i| = 2uz_n + vz_1 + v \sum_{i=1}^n |\Delta z_i| \\ &\leq 2uz_n + vz_1 + nv \sup_{1 \leq i \leq n} |\Delta z_i|. \end{aligned}$$

Since $u < 1$, we have $\alpha < 1$. By $z_n = \Theta(n^\alpha)$, we have $\frac{1}{n}(2uz_n + vz_1) \rightarrow 0$, or

$$|\Delta z_{n+1}| \leq v \sup_{1 \leq i \leq n} |\Delta z_i| + o(1).$$

We have $v < 1$ since otherwise the condition $2u + v > 1$ would be violated. Then $(|\Delta z_i|)$ is bounded. Let $M = \sup_{n \geq 1} |\Delta z_n|$. Let $\epsilon > 0$, then there exists N such that for all $n \geq N$, $|\Delta z_n| < M + \epsilon$. Therefore,

$$|\Delta z_{n+1}| \leq v(M + \epsilon) + o(1).$$

Let $n \rightarrow \infty$, we have $M \leq v(M + \epsilon)$. Since $\epsilon > 0$ is arbitrary, we have $M = 0$. $\square$

Since (z_n) is unbounded, we have the following corollary.

Corollary 3.6 (Eventual exceedance) *Let α be the solution to (3.6). Then, for every $M > 0$, there exists N such that for all $n \geq N$, $z_n > M$.*

Lemma 3.7 (Difference identity) *For all sufficiently large n , there exist numbers $\theta_{n,i} \in [0, 1]$ for $1 \leq i \leq n-1$ such that*

$$n\Delta z_{n+1} = (2u + v - 1)z_n - \Delta z_n + v \sum_{i=1}^{n-1} \theta_{n,i} \Delta z_i. \quad (3.10)$$

Proof. We start from (3.9)

$$n\Delta z_{n+1} = 2uz_n + v \max(z_n, z_1) - z_{n+1} + v \sum_{i=1}^{n-1} (\max(z_i, z_{n+1-i}) - \max(z_i, z_{n-i})).$$

Now with Corollary 3.6, we have $\max(z_n, z_1) = z_n$ for all sufficiently large n . Hence, for all sufficiently large n ,

$$n\Delta z_{n+1} = (2u + v - 1)z_n - \Delta z_n + v \sum_{i=1}^{n-1} (\max(z_{n-i}, z_{i+1}) - \max(z_{n-i}, z_i)).$$

For every $a \geq 0$, the function $x \mapsto \max(a, x)$ is increasing and 1-Lipschitz. Hence for each n, i there is some $\theta_{n,i} \in [0, 1]$ satisfying (3.10). $\square$

At this step, we have isolated the difference sequence (Δz_n) from the original sequence (z_n) . Our next goal is to prove that (Δz_n) is *eventually positive*. That would be done if in (3.10), we can absorb a lower bound of $-\Delta z_n + v \sum_{i=1}^{n-1} \theta_{n,i} \Delta z_i$ into $(2u + v - 1)z_n$. We already have $|\Delta z_n| = o(z_n)$ since (Δz_n) is bounded. Because we do not know much about $\theta_{n,i}$, we can only apply the worst case to

3.2 Asymptotics of the lower bound recurrence

them. A basic inequality for absolute value leads to showing that $\sum_{i=1}^n |\Delta z_i| = o(z_n)$. Unfortunately, if it is true that $z_n \sim Cn^\alpha$ and z_n is eventually increasing, then $\sum_{i=1}^n |\Delta z_i| \sim Cn^\alpha$. Therefore, we need a tighter lower bound. We will use the *negative variation* of Δz_n . For every $x \in \mathbb{R}$, we have

$$x_- := \max(-x, 0) = \frac{1}{2}(|x| - x) \geq -x \iff x \geq -x_-. \quad (3.11)$$

Define the negative variation series (Δz_n) as

$$V_n := \sum_{i=1}^n (\Delta z_i)_-. \quad (3.12)$$

Then (V_n) is increasing. We state the criterion for eventual increase of (z_n) in terms of (V_n) as follows.

Lemma 3.8 (Negative variation criterion) *If $V_n = o(z_n)$, then (z_n) is eventually increasing.*

Proof. By Lemma 3.7, for all sufficiently large n ,

$$n\Delta z_{n+1} \geq (2u + v - 1)z_n - |\Delta z_n| - vV_n.$$

Since Δz_n is bounded and $z_n \rightarrow \infty$, we have $|\Delta z_n| = o(z_n)$. By assumption, $V_n = o(z_n)$. Hence for all sufficiently large n ,

$$n\Delta z_{n+1} \geq \frac{1}{2}(2u + v - 1)z_n > 0.$$

□

It would be perfect if we could prove that (V_n) is bounded, as this is indeed the truth. However, it is already good to prove that $V_n = o(n^\alpha)$, since we already have $z_n = \Theta(n^\alpha)$.

Lemma 3.9 *We have $V_n = O(n^v)$.*

Proof. Again, we start from (3.10). There exists N such that for all $n \geq N$,

$$n\Delta z_{n+1} = (2u + v - 1)z_n - \Delta z_n + v \sum_{i=1}^{n-1} \theta_{n,i} \Delta z_i.$$

Let $M = \sup |\Delta z_n|$. If $\Delta z_{n+1} < 0$, then

$$\begin{aligned} n(\Delta z_{n+1})_- &= -n\Delta z_{n+1} = |\Delta z_n| - (2u + v - 1)z_n - v \sum_{j=1}^{n-1} (\Delta z_j)_- \\ &\leq vV_{n-1} + |\Delta z_n| - (2u + v - 1)z_n \\ &\leq vV_{n-1} + M. \end{aligned}$$

Hence, $(\Delta z_{n+1})_- \leq \frac{v}{n}V_{n-1} + \frac{M}{n} \leq \frac{v}{n}V_n + \frac{M}{n}$. Therefore,

$$V_{n+1} \leq \left(1 + \frac{v}{n}\right) V_n + \frac{M}{n}. \quad (3.13)$$

Note that if $\Delta z_{n+1} \geq 0$, then $(\Delta z_{n+1})_- = 0$, leading to $V_{n+1} = V_n$, or (3.13) holds automatically. We then have

$$V_{n+1} + \frac{M}{v} \leq \left(1 + \frac{v}{n}\right) \left(V_n + \frac{M}{v}\right) \leq \prod_{i=N}^n \left(1 + \frac{v}{i}\right) \left(V_N + \frac{M}{v}\right).$$

3.2 Asymptotics of the lower bound recurrence

We are left to estimate the product. Taking the logarithm gives

$$\begin{aligned} \ln \left(\prod_{i=N}^n \left(1 + \frac{v}{i} \right) \right) &= \sum_{i=N}^n \ln \left(1 + \frac{v}{i} \right) \\ &\leq \sum_{i=N}^n \frac{v}{i} = v(H_n - H_{N-1}) \\ &\leq vH_n \leq v \ln n + C, \end{aligned}$$

where $H_n = \sum_{i=1}^n \frac{1}{i} = \ln n + \gamma + O(1/n)$ is the n -th harmonic number and C is some constant. Taking back the exponential of both sides yields

$$\prod_{i=N}^n \left(1 + \frac{v}{i} \right) \leq e^C n^v = O(n^v).$$

□

We state our checkpoint as a theorem.

Theorem 3.10 *If $v < \alpha$, then (z_n) is eventually increasing.*

Let us reduce the condition $v < \alpha$ in terms of u and v . Define

$$f(\alpha) = \alpha + 1 - 2(u + v) + v2^{-\alpha}, \alpha \in [0, 1].$$

Then $f'(\alpha) = 1 - v2^{-\alpha} \ln 2 > 1 - \ln 2 > 0$ for all $\alpha > 0$. Hence $v < \alpha$ is equivalent to $f(v) < 0$ i.e.,

$$v + 1 - 2(u + v) + v2^{-v} < 0 \iff u > \frac{1}{2}(1 - v + v2^{-v}).$$

If we impose conditions 3.5, then the above inequality is satisfied. The case $v \geq \alpha$ is left open. With (z_n) being eventually increasing, it has a nicer recurrence without the whole history.

Lemma 3.11 *There exists $N \geq 1$ such that the sequence $(z_n)_{n \geq N}$ defined by 3.3 satisfies the recurrence*

$$nz_{n+2} - (n-1)z_{n+1} = 2(u+v)z_n - vz_{\lfloor n/2 \rfloor}. \quad (3.14)$$

with $z_{N+1} \geq z_N \geq \dots \geq z_{\lfloor n/2 \rfloor} \geq 1$.

Proof. Since (z_n) is eventually increasing, there exists N such that for all $n \geq N$, we have $z_n \geq z_i$ for all $1 \leq i \leq n-1$ and $z_n \geq 1$. Hence, for all $n \geq N+1$,

$$\begin{aligned} nz_{n+2} &= 2u \sum_{i=1}^n z_i + 2v \sum_{i=\lfloor n/2 \rfloor + 1}^n z_i + \delta_n vz_{\lfloor n/2 \rfloor} \\ (n-1)z_{n+1} &= 2u \sum_{i=1}^{n-1} z_i + 2v \sum_{i=\lfloor (n-1)/2 \rfloor + 1}^{n-1} z_i + \delta_{n-1} vz_{\lfloor (n-1)/2 \rfloor}, \end{aligned}$$

where $\delta_n = 1$ if n is odd and 0 if n is even. If $n = 2k$, then $\lfloor n/2 \rfloor = \lfloor (n-1)/2 \rfloor = k$, $\delta_n = 0$ and $\delta_{n-1} = 1$. Hence,

$$2kz_{2k+2} - (2k-1)z_{2k+1} = 2(u+v)z_{2k} - vz_k.$$

If $n = 2k+1$, then $\lfloor n/2 \rfloor = \lfloor (n-1)/2 \rfloor = k$, $\delta_n = 1$ and $\delta_{n-1} = 0$. Hence,

$$(2k+1)z_{2k+3} - (2k)z_{2k+2} = 2(u+v)z_{2k+1} - 2vz_{k+1} + vz_{k+1} = (2k+1)(u+v)z_{2k+1} - vz_{k+1}.$$

Collecting the two case cases and noticing that $\left\lceil \frac{n-1}{2} \right\rceil = \left\lfloor \frac{n}{2} \right\rfloor$ we arrive at (3.14) □

3.2 Asymptotics of the lower bound recurrence

With the recurrence (3.14), we can now prove the exact asymptotics of (z_n) . We will use a *dyadic argument* to show that the normalized difference sequence (Δx_n) is absolutely summable by dividing analyzing it in the intervals $[2^m, 2^{m+1})$.

Theorem 3.12 *Let (z_n) be the defined by (3.14) and α be the solution to (3.6). Then $z_n \sim Cn^\alpha$ for some constant $C > 0$.*

Proof. Let $x_n = \frac{z_n}{(n-2)^\alpha}$ for $n \geq N$. We will prove that (x_n) converges by proving that $(x_{n+1} - x_n)$ is absolutely summable, i.e., $\sum_{n \geq N} |x_{n+1} - x_n|$ converges. Note that $x_n = \Theta(1)$ since $z_n = \Theta(n^\alpha)$. For $n \geq N \geq 6$ (so that $x_{\lfloor n/2 \rfloor}$ is defined), we have

$$\begin{aligned} n^{\alpha+1}x_{n+2} - (n-1)^{\alpha+1}x_{n+1} &= 2(u+v)(n-2)^\alpha x_n - v \left(\left\lfloor \frac{n}{2} \right\rfloor - 2 \right)^\alpha x_{\lfloor n/2 \rfloor} \\ \iff x_{n+2} &= \left(1 - \frac{1}{n}\right)^{\alpha+1} x_{n+1} + \frac{2(u+v)}{n} \left(1 - \frac{2}{n}\right)^\alpha x_{n-1} - \frac{v}{n} \left(\frac{\lfloor n/2 \rfloor - 2}{n} \right)^\alpha x_{\lfloor n/2 \rfloor}. \end{aligned}$$

We have

$$\left(1 - \frac{1}{n}\right)^{\alpha+1} = 1 - \frac{\alpha+1}{n} + O\left(\frac{1}{n^2}\right), \quad \frac{1}{n} \left(1 - \frac{2}{n}\right)^\alpha = \frac{1}{n} + O\left(\frac{1}{n^2}\right), \quad \frac{1}{n} \left(\frac{\lfloor n/2 \rfloor - 2}{n} \right)^\alpha = \frac{2^{-\alpha}}{n} + O\left(\frac{1}{n^2}\right).$$

The last expansion is because $\frac{1}{2} - \frac{3}{n} \leq \frac{\lfloor n/2 \rfloor - 2}{n} \leq \frac{1}{2} - \frac{1}{n}$. Since α solves (3.6), we have

$$\begin{aligned} x_{n+2} - x_{n+1} &= -\frac{\alpha+1}{n}x_{n+1} + \frac{2(u+v)}{n}x_n - \frac{v2^{-\alpha}}{n}x_{\lfloor n/2 \rfloor} + O\left(\frac{1}{n^2}\right) \\ &= -\frac{2(u+v)}{n}(x_{n+1} - x_n) + \frac{v2^{-\alpha}}{n}(x_n - x_{\lfloor n/2 \rfloor}) + O\left(\frac{1}{n^2}\right). \end{aligned}$$

Let $\Delta x_n = x_n - x_{n-1}$. The difference operator of x_n is not the same as that of Δz_n , for the reason that will be clear soon. There exists a constant $K_1 > 0$ such that for every $n \geq N' - 2 \geq N$,

$$|\Delta x_{n+2}| \leq \frac{2(u+v)}{n}|\Delta x_{n+1}| + \frac{v2^{-\alpha}}{n} \sum_{i=\lfloor n/2 \rfloor + 1}^n |\Delta x_i| + \frac{K_1}{(n+2)^2}.$$

Equivalently, for $n \geq N'$,

$$|\Delta x_n| \leq \frac{2(u+v)}{n-2}|\Delta x_{n-1}| + \frac{v2^{-\alpha}}{n-2} \sum_{i=\lfloor n/2 \rfloor}^{n-2} |\Delta x_i| + \frac{K_1}{n^2}.$$

Let $u_m = \max_{2^m \leq n < 2^{m+1}} |\Delta x_n|$. Then, for every $n \in [2^m, 2^{m+1})$, we have

$$\begin{aligned} |\Delta x_{n-1}| &\leq \max_{2^{m-1} \leq i < 2^m - 1} |\Delta x_i| \leq \max(u_{m-1}, u_m), \\ \frac{1}{n-2} \sum_{i=\lfloor n/2 \rfloor}^{n-2} |\Delta x_i| &\leq \frac{1}{2} \max_{2^{m-1} \leq i < 2^m - 2} |\Delta x_i| \leq \frac{1}{2} \max(u_{m-1}, u_m). \end{aligned}$$

Therefore,

$$|\Delta x_n| \leq \left(\frac{2(u+v)}{n-2} + v2^{-\alpha-1} \right) \max(u_{m-1}, u_m) + \frac{K_1}{2^{2m}}.$$

Taking the maximum over $n \in [2^m, 2^{m+1})$, we have

$$u_m \leq \left(\frac{2(u+v)}{n-2} + v2^{-\alpha-1} \right) \max(u_{m-1}, u_m) + \frac{K_1}{2^{2m}}.$$

3.3 Asymptotics of the original recurrence

Now the reason for redefining the difference operator and shifting the indices is clear: we need the left-hand side index to be n to take the maximum over the window $[2^m, 2^{m+1})$, while the right-hand side does not span over more than two windows. Since $v2^{-\alpha} = 2(u+v) - \alpha - 1 < 1$, we can choose m_0 large enough such that $2^{m_0} \geq N'$, and there exists γ_1 such that

$$\frac{2(u+v)}{n-2} + v2^{-\alpha-1} < \gamma_1 < \frac{1}{2}$$

for all $m \geq m_0$ and $n \in [2^m, 2^{m+1})$. If $u_{m-1} > u_m$, then $u_m \leq \gamma_1 u_{m-1} + \frac{K_1}{2^{2m}}$. If $u_{m-1} \leq u_m$, then $u_m \leq \frac{K_1}{2^{2m}(1-\gamma_1)}$. In both cases, we have

$$\begin{aligned} u_m &\leq \gamma_1 u_{m-1} + \frac{K_1}{2^{2m}(1-\gamma_1)} \\ &\leq \sum_{i=m_0+1}^m \gamma_1^{m-i} \frac{K_1}{2^{2i}(1-\gamma_1)} + \gamma_1^{m-m_0} u_{m_0} \\ &< \frac{K_1}{(1-\gamma_1)} \sum_{i=m_0+1}^m \gamma_1^{m-i} \left(\frac{1}{4}\right)^i + \gamma_1^{m-m_0} u_{m_0}. \end{aligned}$$

Choose γ_2 such that $\max\left(\gamma_1, \frac{1}{4}\right) < \gamma_2 < \frac{1}{2}$. We have

$$u_m < \frac{K_1}{(1-\gamma_1)} \sum_{i=m_0+1}^m \gamma_2^m + \gamma_2^{m-m_0} u_{m_0} \leq K_2 m \gamma_2^m,$$

for some constant $K_2 > 0$. Choose γ_3 such that $\gamma_2 < \gamma_3 < \frac{1}{2}$. Then there exists $m_1 > m_0$ such that for every $m \geq m_1$, we have $K_2 m \gamma_2^m < K_2 \gamma_3^m$, implying that,

$$u_m < K_2 \gamma_3^m.$$

Therefore,

$$\sum_{n=N'+1}^{\infty} |\Delta x_m| \leq \sum_{m=\lfloor \log_2(N') \rfloor}^{\infty} \sum_{n=2^m}^{2^{m+1}-1} |\Delta x_n| < \sum_{m=\lfloor \log_2(N') \rfloor}^{m_1-1} 2^m u_m + K_2 \sum_{m=m_1}^{\infty} (2\gamma_3)^m < \infty.$$

Hence, (x_n) converges to some constant $C > 0$. Thus, $z_n \sim Cn^\alpha$. $\square$

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3.3.1 Proof strategy

The stochastic recurrence (2.1) looks similar to its deterministic counterpart (3.3). With the results that the lower and upper bounds grow as a pure power of n , it is plausible to conjecture the same situation for the original sequence (y_n) . However, if it is true that $y_n \sim Cn^{\alpha^*}$, then experiments show that α^* is strictly larger than the solution to (3.6). Intuitively, in long-term, $\mathbb{E}[\max(Y_i, Y_j)]$ is still more selective than $\max(\mathbb{E}[Y_i], \mathbb{E}[Y_j])$, especially when i and j are close to each other.

In this section, we present an on-going attempt towards the weakest asymptotic result $y_n = n^{\alpha^*+o(1)}$. We adapt the contraction method (e.g., [6]). The original idea is as follows.

1. Guess the scaling factor and derive the normalized recurrence.

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2. Derive a limiting fixed-point equation from the normalized recurrence.
3. Prove that the limiting equation has a unique solution in a suitable metric space using a contraction argument.
4. Prove that the normalized sequence converges in distribution to that unique solution.

The contraction method does not directly apply to our case. Let $X_n = Y_n/n^\alpha$ for $\alpha > 0$. We have the recurrence for X_n and the limiting equation as follows.

$$X_{n+2} \stackrel{d}{=} I \left(\left(\frac{U_n}{n+2} \right)^\alpha X_{U_n}^{(1)} + \left(\frac{n+1-U_n}{n+2} \right)^\alpha X_{n+1-U_n}^{(2)} \right) + J \max \left(\left(\frac{U_n}{n+2} \right)^\alpha X_{U_n}^{(1)}, \left(\frac{n+1-U_n}{n+2} \right)^\alpha X_{n+1-U_n}^{(2)} \right) \quad (3.15)$$

Lemma 3.13 (Limiting equation) *Suppose that $X_n \xrightarrow{d} X$. Then, X satisfies the following distributional equation*

$$X \stackrel{d}{=} I \left(U^\alpha X^{(1)} + (1-U)^\alpha X^{(2)} \right) + J \max(U^\alpha X^{(1)}, (1-U)^\alpha X^{(2)}), \quad (3.16)$$

where $U \sim \text{Unif}[0, 1]$.

The proof of Lemma 3.13 is given in Appendix A.4.1. Let $\mathcal{D}$ be the space of probability measures on $\mathbb{R}$. Our first goal is to prove that there exists a unique solution (X^*, α^*) to (3.16) in some subspace of $\mathcal{D}$. Hence now the question is how to choose the subspace. The fixed-point equation (3.16) always has an undesired solution δ_0 , so the subspace should exclude δ_0 . Define the operator $T : \mathcal{D} \rightarrow \mathcal{D}$ induced by the right-hand side of (3.16) as

$$T_\alpha(\mu) = \mathcal{L} \left(I \left(U^\alpha X^{(1)} + (1-U)^\alpha X^{(2)} \right) + J \max(U^\alpha X^{(1)}, (1-U)^\alpha X^{(2)}) \right), \quad X^{(1)}, X^{(2)} \stackrel{\text{iid}}{\sim} \mu. \quad (3.17)$$

Define the recurrence according to T_α as

$$\mu_{n+1} = T_\alpha(\mu_n), \quad n \geq 1, \quad (3.18)$$

and μ_1 is some initial distribution. The contraction argument may not work. If T_α were a contraction in the Wasserstein metric for some α , the sequence would collapse to δ_0 from any μ_1 . While the Zolotarev metric allows us to choose a subspace excluding δ_0 , it requires certain first moments to remain fixed—a condition T_α violates, as it does not preserve the mean.

An intuition behind the evolution of (3.18) is as follows. Let α be fixed. At each iteration, T_α alters the shape of the distribution μ_n . Depending on the “dispersion” of μ_n , T_α will either increase or decrease its mean. If α is too large, T_α drives the mean to 0 before the distribution becomes sufficiently dispersed. Conversely, if α is too small, T_α pushes the mean to infinity once the distribution is adequately dispersed. The mean is not positively correlated with the need for a larger α . Let $\mu = \delta_2$ and $\nu = 2\text{Ber}(1/2)$, then $\mathbb{E}_{X \sim \mu}[X] = 2 > 1 = \mathbb{E}_{Y \sim \nu}[Y]$. Then let α solve 3.6. Then $\mathbb{E}_{X \sim \mu}[T_\alpha(X)] = \mathbb{E}_{X \sim \mu}[X]$ but $\mathbb{E}_{Y \sim \nu}[T_\alpha(Y)] > \mathbb{E}_{Y \sim \nu}[Y]$. That means although μ has a larger mean than ν , it requires a smaller α to keep its mean fixed. This is because ν is more dispersed than μ . Unfortunately, the second moment is still not sufficient. One can build a similar counterexample by choosing μ and ν of the same mean, $\mathbb{E}_{X \sim \mu}[X^2] > \mathbb{E}_{Y \sim \nu}[Y^2]$, and $\mathbb{E}_{X \sim \mu}[X^3] < \mathbb{E}_{Y \sim \nu}[Y^3]$. If the third moments differ enough comparing to how different the second moments are, then $\mathbb{E}_{X \sim \mu}[T_\alpha(X)] < \mathbb{E}_{Y \sim \nu}[T_\alpha(Y)]$. Now it is clear that no finite number of moments is sufficient to determine the correct α that keeps the mean fixed.

Another observation is that for each fixed μ , there exists a unique α that keeps the mean fixed. We state it below and leave the proof in Appendix A.4.2.

3.3 Asymptotics of the original recurrence

Proposition 3.14 *Define the function $f : \mathcal{D}(1) \times (0, 1] \rightarrow \mathbb{R}_+$ as*

$$f(\mu, \alpha) = \mathbb{E}_{Y \sim T_\alpha(\mu)}[X] = \frac{2u}{\alpha + 1} + v \mathbb{E}_{X^{(1)}, X^{(2)} \sim \mu} \left[\max \left(U^\alpha X^{(1)}, (1 - U)^\alpha X^{(2)} \right) \right].$$

For every $\mu \in \mathcal{D}_2(1)$, there exists a unique $\alpha \in [\alpha_0, 2(u + v) - 1]$, where α_0 solves (3.6), such that $f(\mu, \alpha) = 1$. Moreover, the range is sharp:

$$\forall \alpha \in (0, \alpha_0), f(\mu, \alpha) > 1 \text{ and } \forall \epsilon \in (0, 2u + v - 1 - \alpha_0), \exists \mu \in \mathcal{D}_2(1), f(\mu, \alpha) = 1.$$

A promising alternative approach is thus to let the distribution and its mean-preserving operator evolve together. By Proposition 3.14, the function $\alpha : \mathcal{D}(1) \rightarrow (0, 1]$ such that $\mathbb{E}_{X \sim \mu}[T_{\alpha(\mu)}(X)] = 1$ is well-defined. We can then define the mean-preserving recurrence as follows.

$$\mu_{n+1} = T_{\alpha_n}(\mu_n), \quad \alpha_n = \alpha(\mu_n) \quad \mu_1 = \delta_1, \quad \alpha_1 = \alpha(\mu_1). \quad (3.19)$$

figures for the algorithm

Proving that (μ_n, α_n) converges may be challenging. We would like to track a quantity that evolves monotonically with the iterations. Simulations support the fact that moments higher than the first moment are monotonically increasing. However, we could not prove that fact, probably as discussed above, because they cannot be used to determine the correct α that keeps the mean fixed. Our strategy is as follows.

1. Prove that there exists a unique solution (X^*, α^*) to (3.16).
2. Prove that for every $\epsilon > 0$, $\mathbb{E}[Y_n/n^{\alpha^* + \epsilon}] \rightarrow 0$ and $\mathbb{E}[Y_n/n^{\alpha^* - \epsilon}] \rightarrow \infty$.
3. Prove that 3.19 converges to (X^*, α^*) .

In the next subsection, we present a partial result towards the first step.

3.3.2 Partial proof of uniqueness of the fixed point

Since the contraction argument may not be applicable to proving the uniqueness of the fixed point, we decompose the problem to proving existence and then uniqueness. We will use Tychonoff fixed-point theorem to prove existence.

Theorem 3.15 (Tychonoff [11, Exercise 2.5c]) *Let $\mathcal{C}$ be a nonempty, compact, convex subset of a locally convex space $\mathcal{M}$. Let $f : \mathcal{C} \rightarrow \mathcal{C}$ be a continuous mapping. Then f has a fixed point.*

Now we have to prepare the ingredients for the Tychonoff fixed-point theorem. The optimal choice for the subset $\mathcal{C}$ is to as small as possible, while containing (μ_n) in (3.19) and $(\mathcal{L}(X_n))$ for X_n defined in (3.15) for all $\alpha \in (2u + v - 1, 2u + v)$. This is because it is more likely to guarantee uniqueness once existence is established. Define $\Phi : \mathcal{D}(1) \rightarrow \mathcal{D}(1)$ such that

$$\Phi(\mu) = T_{\alpha(\mu)}(\mu), \quad \forall \mu \in \mathcal{D}(1). \quad (3.20)$$

In the followings, we will show that the subset $\mathcal{C}$ can be restricted to the set of distributions with uniformly bounded second moment.

3.3 Asymptotics of the original recurrence

Proposition 3.16 *Assume that $u > 1/2$. Then for every*

$$M \geq M_0 := 2uB(2u+v, 2u+v) \frac{2(2u+v) - 1}{2u - 1},$$

the operator Φ defined in (3.20) maps $\mathcal{D}_2(1, M)$ into itself.

The proof is given in Appendix A.4.3. Again, the condition $u > 1/2$ is crucial. If we follow (3.18), then it is possible to choose $M = \max(1, M_0)$. In $\mathcal{D}_2(1, M)$, the range in Proposition 3.14 can be slightly improved to $\left[\alpha_0, 2(u+v) - 1 - \frac{v}{2M}\right)$.

The next ingredient is the host vector space $\mathcal{M}$. To reduce excessive elaboration, it is better to follow the probabilists' preference. That is to define the notion of convergence using the space $C_b(\mathbb{R})$ of bounded, continuous test functions [1, Chap. 1]. On the other hand, to have local convexity of $\mathcal{M}$ right away, we follow the functional analysts' practice. That is to equip $C_b(\mathbb{R})$ with a topology and define $\mathcal{M}$ as its dual space, which is the space of continuous linear functionals. Finally, it is enough to have $\mathcal{D}_2(1, M)$ compact in $\mathcal{M}$. However, just as we wanted $\mathcal{D}_2(1, M)$ to be just enough to contain our distributions of interest, we also want $\mathcal{M}$ to be just enough to contain $\mathcal{D}_2(1, M)$, as $\mathcal{M}$ would be more well-behaved.

We could construct (μ^*, α^*) . Are we cheating by using the axiom of choice somewhere?

Is $\mathcal{D}_2(1)$ compact in $\mathcal{M}$?



Appendix

A.1 The Shift-Or algorithm

Let Σ be the alphabet, T be the text, and P be the pattern. Suppose that we have registers of length w bits. This requires that $|P| \leq w$. As usual, we index characters in the pattern P and T from left to right, starting from 0. But for the registers, it is convenient to index bits from right to left (LSB), starting from 0.

In the compile stage, we construct masks for each character in the alphabet, which we denote by a function $M : \Sigma \rightarrow \{0, 1\}^w$. For each character $c \in \Sigma$, we have

$$\begin{aligned} P[i] = c &\iff M[c][i] = 0, \quad i \in [0, |P| - 1] \\ &M[c][i] = 1, \quad i \in [|P|, w - 1] \end{aligned} \tag{1.1}$$

The execution stage is as follows. We initialize a state register S to all 1s ($S \leftarrow \sim 0$). At each step $i \geq 0$, the register S is updated according to the following formula

$$S \leftarrow (S \ll 1) \mid M[T[i]]. \tag{1.2}$$

The algorithm leverages the fact that every time the state register is shifted to the left, a 0 is introduced at the least significant bit. This 0 is then propagated to the left as long as the characters in the text match the characters in the pattern. If a mismatch occurs, that 0 is replaced by a 1, and the propagation stops. The state register S keeps track of the longest prefix of the pattern that matches a suffix of the text ending at position i . At step i , if $S[|P| - 1] = 0$, then there is a match ending at position i in the text. Correctness is proved by using induction to check the invariant: at step i , we have

$$S[j] = 0 \iff T[i - j, i] = P[0, j], \forall j \in [0, |P| - 1]. \tag{1.3}$$

Example A.1. ■

A.2 BST-like distributions of regular expression trees

Lemma A.1 (Asymptotics of recurrence of full history sum)

A.3 Basics of Monte-Carlo simulation

A.4 Remaining proofs

A.4.1 Lemma 3.13

A.4.2 Proposition 3.14

Proof. It is clear that f is strictly decreasing in α . Next, we show that f is continuous. The first term is continuous. We show that the second term is Lipschitz continuous. Let $\alpha, \alpha' \in (0, 1]$ and assume without loss of generality that $\alpha > \alpha'$. We have

$$\begin{aligned}
& \mathbb{E} \left[\max \left(U^\alpha X^{(1)}, (1-U)^\alpha X^{(2)} \right) - \max \left(U^{\alpha'} X^{(1)}, (1-U)^{\alpha'} X^{(2)} \right) \right] \\
& \leq \mathbb{E} \left[\max \left(\left| U^\alpha - U^{\alpha'} \right| X^{(1)}, \left| (1-U)^\alpha - (1-U)^{\alpha'} \right| X^{(2)} \right) \right] \\
& \leq \mathbb{E} \left[\left| U^\alpha - U^{\alpha'} \right| \right] + \mathbb{E} \left[\left| (1-U)^\alpha - (1-U)^{\alpha'} \right| \right] \\
& = 2\mathbb{E} \left[\left| U^\alpha - U^{\alpha'} \right| \right] \quad (U \stackrel{d}{=} 1-U) \\
& = 2\mathbb{E} \left[U^{\alpha'} - U^\alpha \right] \quad (U^\alpha \geq U^{\alpha'}, a.s.) \\
& = \frac{2}{\alpha' + 1} - \frac{2}{\alpha + 1} = \frac{2(\alpha - \alpha')}{(\alpha + 1)(\alpha' + 1)} \\
& \leq 2(\alpha - \alpha').
\end{aligned}$$

Finally, we evaluate f at the endpoints.

$$\begin{aligned}
\lim_{\alpha \rightarrow 0+} f(\mu, \alpha) &= 2u + v \mathbb{E} \left[\max \left(X^{(1)}, X^{(2)} \right) \right] > 2u + v > 1, \\
f(1) &= u + v \mathbb{E} \left[\max \left(U^\alpha X^{(1)}, (1-U)^\alpha X^{(2)} \right) \right] \leq u + v \leq 1.
\end{aligned}$$

□

A.4.3 Proposition 3.16

Proof. Let $\mu \in \mathcal{D}_2(1)$ have finite second moment. Let $Z \sim \mu$. Follow the steps in the previous section, we have

$$\begin{aligned}
\mathbb{E} [\Phi(Z)^2] &\leq \frac{2(u+v)}{2\alpha+1} \mathbb{E} [Z^2] + 2uB(\alpha+1, \alpha+1) \\
&< \frac{2(u+v)}{2(2u+v)-1} \mathbb{E} [Z^2] + 2uB(2u+v, 2u+v)
\end{aligned}$$

Choose

$$M_0 = 2uB(2u+v, 2u+v) \left(1 - \frac{2(u+v)}{2(2u+v)-1} \right) = 2uB(2u+v, 2u+v) \frac{2(2u+v)-1}{2u-1}.$$

we have $\mathbb{E} [\Phi(Z)^2] \leq M$. Hence, Φ maps $\mathcal{D}_2(1, M)$ into itself.

□

B

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